The Manufactured Divine

Power, Identity, and the Trajectory of Sacred Authority from Tribal Origin to Eschatological Risk

Soumadeep Ghosh

Kolkata, India

Abstract

This paper examines the evolutionary trajectory of monotheistic divine authority, with particular focus on the Abrahamic tradition as expressed through Jewish theological history. Drawing on anthropology, historiography, political theory, philosophy of religion, and contemporary geopolitics, we argue that the God concept as institutionally deployed has consistently served structures of power rather than the values — justice, illumination, protection of the vulnerable — ostensibly in whose name it operates. We trace a coherent arc from tribal deity to universal sovereign, analyse the recurring pattern of *cost asymmetry* (wherein those who construct theological authority rarely bear the consequences of that authority), and examine the technological escalation of religiously legitimated violence from the sword to the intercontinental ballistic missile. We conclude that the absence of an infallible God may be less a metaphysical fact than a sociological inevitability: a genuinely infallible deity would be functionally incompatible with the political uses to which the divine has historically been put. The paper closes by considering whether the values traditionally attributed to the divine — justice, light, accountability — can be sustained without the theological infrastructure that has so consistently betrayed them.

The paper ends with "The End"

Keywords: theodicy, comparative religion, political theology, Yahwism, cost asymmetry, eschatological risk, atheism, process theology, divine evolution, geopolitical religion.

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1 Introduction: The Problem of the Withheld Light

The philosophical tradition has long interrogated the relationship between divine authority and human illumination. From Prometheus chained to his rock to the Gnostic demiurge jealously guarding gnosis, a persistent counter-narrative runs alongside orthodox monotheism: that the divine, as institutionally defined, is less a source of light than a regulator of it.

This paper takes that counter-narrative seriously as a structural observation rather than a polemical claim. We do not begin from atheism, nor do we end there necessarily. We begin from a simpler and more verifiable premise: that the God actually operative in human history — the God whose name has been invoked to justify conquest, persecution, covenant, and now nuclear deterrence — bears systematic characteristics that deserve rigorous examination.

Three preliminary observations organise our inquiry:

1. The *textual record* of the major Abrahamic scriptures contains, within itself, evidence of the kind of divine limitation and human construction we describe. The God of the Hebrew Bible is not consistently omnipotent; other gods are acknowledged as real; Yahweh evolves in character across the corpus.

2. The *sociological record* of how divine authority has been deployed consistently shows that those who construct theological frameworks rarely bear the costs imposed on those who inherit them.

3. The *geopolitical present* represents a convergence of religiously legitimated national identities with weapons capable of civilisational destruction — making these questions not merely academic but urgently practical.

The structure of the paper follows the logical arc from theological origin through institutional development to contemporary consequence.

2 The Origin of Yahweh: From Local Deity to Universal Sovereign

2.1 Archaeological and Textual Evidence for Yahweh's Regional Origins

Contemporary biblical archaeology and comparative religious studies have substantially revised the popular understanding of Israelite monotheism as a sudden, revealed, and always-absolute conviction. The scholarly consensus, represented by figures such as Mark Smith, William Dever, and Israel Finkelstein, holds that Yahweh originated as a regional deity within the broader Canaanite pantheon, likely associated with storm, war, and the southern wilderness regions of Sinai and Edom [1].

Several features of the textual record support this reading:

- The formula *"You shall have no other gods before me"* (Exodus 20:3) presupposes the existence of other gods rather than denying it.

- Early poetry within the Hebrew Bible (Deuteronomy 32, Psalm 82) depicts Yahweh as one divine being among many who is elevated or who claims supremacy — not as the sole existing deity.

- The absorption of attributes from other Canaanite deities — El's fatherhood and cosmic seniority, Baal's storm imagery — is traceable across the biblical corpus.

- The personal name Yahweh is absent from the patriarchal narratives in their earliest strata, replaced by *El Shaddai* and *El Elyon* — names associated with the generic Canaanite high god [2].

2.2 The Political Theology of Monotheisation

The consolidation of Yahweh as the sole deity — strict monotheism rather than monolatry — is most plausibly dated to the period of the Josianic reform (late 7th century BCE) and the Babylonian exile (6th century BCE). Both moments are politically significant: Josiah's centralisation of worship in Jerusalem served clear nation-building purposes, while the exilic reinterpretation of catastrophe as divine punishment rather than divine defeat served to preserve communal identity under conquest.

This observation is not merely reductive. It does not *disprove* divine inspiration. But it establishes that the theological claim of universal sovereignty was developed, refined, and deployed in contexts where it served identifiable political interests. The God who began as a local champion was rewritten, across several centuries, into the creator of the cosmos.

3 The Chosen People: Covenant as Contract, Identity as Risk

3.1 The Structure of Election Theology

The concept of divine election — that Yahweh chose Israel specifically and uniquely among the nations — is central to Jewish self-understanding and, derivatively, to Christian and Islamic theology. Its theological elaboration ranges from the unconditional covenant with Abraham (Genesis 15) to the conditional covenant of Sinai (Exodus 19–24) to the prophetic reformulations under pressure of exile.

We propose that election theology, examined structurally, has three consistent features across its historical manifestations:

1. **Differentiation**: The chosen group is marked as distinct from surrounding peoples, through law, practice, or lineage.
2. **Divine Guarantee**: The distinctiveness is underwritten by a cosmic authority, making it non-negotiable in principle.
3. **Asymmetric Consequence**: The distinction confers both promised benefit and actual vulnerability — a visibility that attracts persecution as readily as it confers dignity.

3.2 The Cost Asymmetry Problem

We introduce the concept of *cost asymmetry* as a central analytical tool. Cost asymmetry refers to the systematic divergence between those who construct or maintain a theological framework and those who bear its consequences.

Table 1 illustrates this pattern across several historical instances within the Abrahamic tradition.

Table 1: Cost Asymmetry in Theological-Political Frameworks

Period	Theological Claim	Framework Architects	Cost Bearers
Josianic Reform, 621 BCE	Yahweh alone; Jerusalem alone	Priestly elite, scribes	Rural Israelites, northern tribes
Early Christianity, 1–4c	Israel superseded; Church chosen	Church Fathers, councils	Jewish communities across empire
Crusades, 1095–1291	Holy war mandated by God	Popes, nobles, clerics	Peasant soldiers, Jewish communities
Reformation, 16c	Scripture alone; elect predestined	Theologians, princes	Civilians in religious wars
Zionism, 1880s–1948	Return to promised land divinely sanctioned	Ideologues, diaspora elite	Palestinian Arabs, later Israeli civilians
Islamic Revolution, 1979	Divine governance (velayat-e faqih)	Clerical hierarchy	Iranian citizens, regional minorities
Christian Nationalism, 21c	God and nation as unified project	Political-religious elite	Minority communities, secularists

The pattern is consistent across traditions, geographies, and centuries. Those who articulate the theological mandate rarely die in its service. Those who inherit the identity — by birth, by geography, by circumstance — bear the consequences they did not choose.

4 The Technological Arc: From the Pen to the ICBM

4.1 Violence and the Increasing Severance of Action from Consequence

One of the most significant developments in the history of religiously legitimated violence is not theological but technological. As the instruments of violence have become more powerful and more remote, the moral feedback loop between action and consequence has progressively attenuated.

We identify the following developmental arc:

Pen → Sword → Gun → Rifle → Cannon → Bomber → ICBM

Each transition in this sequence involves not merely an increase in destructive capacity but a qualitative transformation in the relationship between the agent of violence and its victim.

Figure 1 illustrates the inverse relationship between weapon range and agent accountability across this arc.

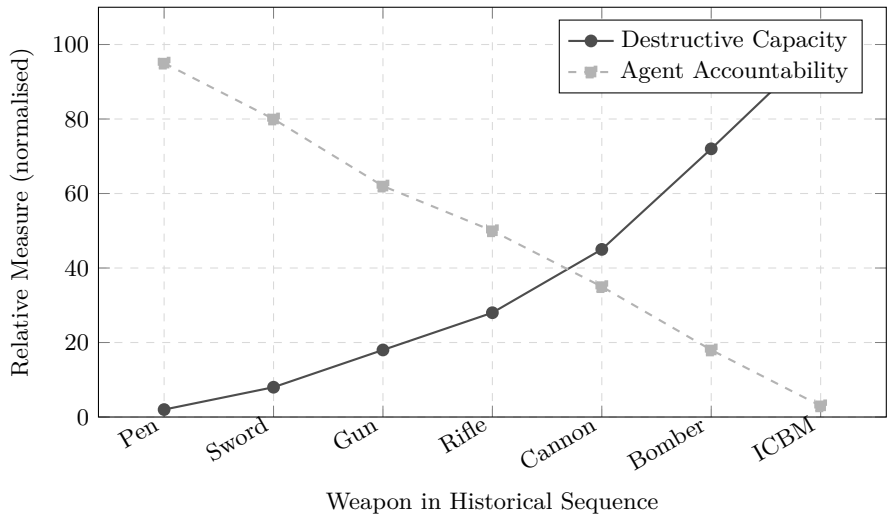

Figure 1: The inverse relationship between destructive capacity and agent accountability across the arc of weaponised technology. As instruments of violence become more powerful, the agent's proximity to consequence approaches zero.

4.2 The Pen as Origin

It is significant that the arc begins with the pen rather than with a weapon in the conventional sense. The foundational acts of religious violence are textual: the writing of covenant, the declaration of chosen status, the naming of the enemy as other. These textual acts — committed by scribes, priests, and ideologues — set in motion consequences that unfold across centuries and are ultimately borne by those who had no part in the original writing.

The ICBM represents the logical completion of this trajectory. The missile requires no soldier, no proximity, no eye contact with the victim. It requires a political decision, a theological or ideological frame that makes the target legitimate, and a technical operator entirely removed from consequence. The scribe who wrote the first covenant and the officer who enters the launch code are separated by millennia but connected by the same logic: maximal consequence, minimal personal accountability.

5 The Evolutionary God: Process, Construction, and the Impossibility of Infallibility

5.1 Process Theology and Divine Development

The tradition of process theology, developed most systematically by Alfred North Whitehead and Charles Hartshorne, proposes that God is not a static, omnipotent being but a developing reality genuinely affected by and in relationship with creation [3]. On this account, God does not simply determine the world but persuades it; divine power is not coercive but relational.

This framework has significant resonances with the historical reconstruction of Yahweh's development. If the God of Israel began as a regional war deity and developed toward universal moral sovereign across several centuries of textual elaboration, this is not simply evidence of human projection. It might also be understood, within process terms, as genuine divine development — a God who grows in relation to the community that engages with him.

However, process theology must be distinguished from the more sociologically precise claim we advance here: that the development of the God concept has been systematically shaped by the interests of those who controlled its elaboration, and that this shaping has consistently produced a God useful to power rather than threatening to it.

5.2 The Infallibility Paradox

We propose the *infallibility paradox* as follows:

> A genuinely infallible God — perfectly just, incorruptible, equally protective of all persons, immune to selective interpretation — would be functionally useless to every human power structure that has historically invoked the divine. Such a God could not be recruited for tribal exclusivism, national expansion, persecution of minorities, or the legitimation of asymmetric violence. The characteristics that would make a God genuinely worthy of worship are precisely the characteristics that make such a God unavailable for political use.

The absence of an infallible God in human institutional history is therefore not surprising. Such a God was never selected for. The Gods that survived and thrived were those whose attributes could be shaped to serve the communities — and more specifically the elites within those communities — who maintained their worship.

Table 2 compares the attributes of a hypothetically infallible God against the attributes of the God as institutionally deployed.

Table 2: Hypothetically Infallible God vs. Institutionally Deployed God

Attribute	**Infallible God**	**Institutional God**
Scope of concern	All persons equally	Chosen group primarily
Interpretive stability	Non-negotiable; no selective reading	Endlessly reinterpreted by authorities
Relationship to power	Threatens all human power equally	Legitimates existing hierarchies
Accountability	Holds all actors equally accountable	Accountability deferred or denied
Response to suffering	Consistently intervenes or explains	Silent; interpreted post-hoc
Compatibility with violence	None; just war impossible to mandate	Regularly mandated
Utility to elites	Zero	High

6 Antisemitism, Election, and the Paradox of Chosen Identity

6.1 The Structural Production of Vulnerability

The history of antisemitism illuminates the cost asymmetry dynamic with particular clarity. The claim that Israel is divinely chosen and set apart from the nations — whatever its theological validity — produced a community that was:

- Visibly distinct through religious practice and social separation
- Theologically threatening to successor traditions (Christianity, Islam) that required the supersession or incorporation of the original claim
- Economically useful to host societies while remaining legally vulnerable within them
- Available as a scapegoat during periods of social crisis, having been pre-marked as *other* by centuries of theological othering

The Holocaust was not caused by election theology. Its causes were specific: the crisis of the Weimar Republic, the ideological innovation of racial antisemitism, the bureaucratic capacity of the modern state, the failure of European democracies to resist. But the Holocaust was made cognitively available — its victims pre-identified, their difference pre-established — by the long history of theological differentiation that election theology initiated and Christian supersessionism intensified.

6.2 The Internal Jewish Response

It is significant that the Jewish tradition itself contains the most searching internal critique of this dynamic. The book of Job is, in essence, a prolonged theological protest against the doctrine that suffering implies guilt and that divine justice operates in transparent ways. God's answer to Job — a theophany that refuses to explain itself — is either a profound acknowledgment of divine transcendence or a divine evasion, depending on one's reading.

Post-Holocaust theology sharpened this critique to its existential extreme. Elie Wiesel's account of a mock trial of God conducted in the camps, ending in a verdict of guilty followed by evening prayer, captures the dialectical structure of Jewish theological protest: the relationship is maintained *through* the accusation, not despite it [4].

7 Contemporary Geopolitics: The Convergence of Sacred Authority and Existential Weaponry

7.1 The Current Landscape

The contemporary Middle Eastern conflict complex — involving Israel, Palestine, Iran, the United States, and their respective allies and proxies — represents a convergence of several dynamics analysed in this paper:

- Competing claims of divine mandate over the same territory
- National identities substantially constituted by religious differentiation
- External powers whose domestic religious constituencies shape foreign policy
- State and non-state actors operating within or adjacent to nuclear capability
- Alliance systems capable of transforming regional conflict into broader conflagration

Figure 2 maps the principal actors and their theological-political alignment in the current conflict complex.

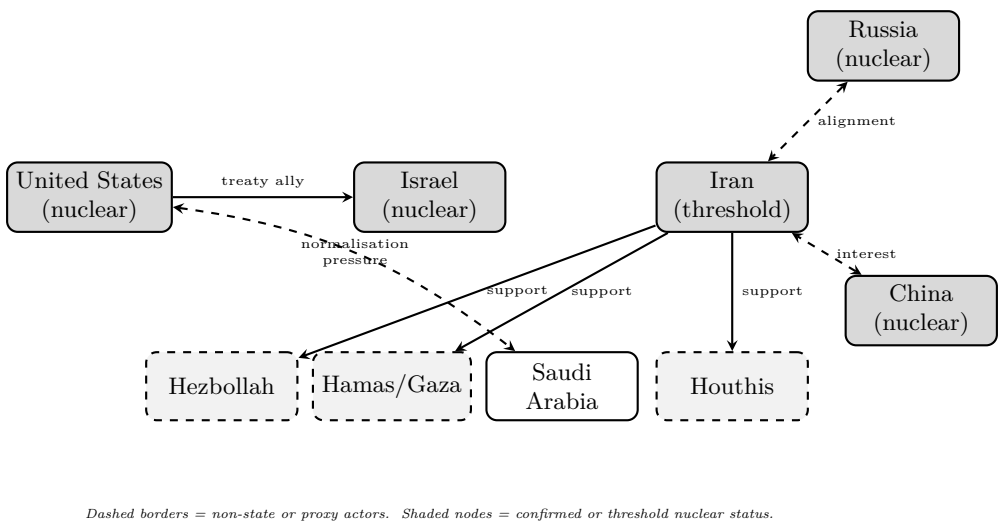

Figure 2: Principal actors in the contemporary Middle Eastern conflict complex, showing theological-political alignment, proxy relationships, and nuclear status.

7.2 Religious Framing as Political Instrument

It is analytically important to distinguish between the religious convictions of ordinary participants in this conflict and the religious framing deployed by political leadership. Research in political psychology consistently shows that leaders of religiously framed conflicts benefit from the conflict remaining religiously defined, because:

1. Religious framing makes the conflict appear non-negotiable, reducing pressure for political compromise
2. It mobilises domestic constituencies who would not support purely national-interest calculations
3. It elevates leaders from the status of politicians — who can be held accountable — to the status of divine agents, who cannot
4. It makes the cost-bearers of the conflict — soldiers, civilians, refugees — willing to accept costs they might otherwise refuse

This dynamic is observable in Israeli settler theology, Iranian velayat-e faqih doctrine, and American Christian Zionism simultaneously. The theological content differs; the political function is identical.

8 Atheism, Secular Alternatives, and the Persistence of the Problem

8.1 The Case for Atheism as Structural Relief

Given the analysis above, the claim that atheism represents an improvement over religiously grounded politics has considerable force. If the problem is the availability of divine authority as a legitimating resource for power, then the removal of that resource should reduce the problem.

The specific advantages of atheist or secular frameworks include:

- Accountability is located in human agents rather than deferred to the unknowable divine will
- Inherited religious identity — which individuals do not choose — cannot be used to mark them as targets
- No cosmic mandate is available to justify the exemption of powerful actors from ordinary moral scrutiny
- The *othering* dynamic, while not eliminated, loses its most powerful legitimating source

8.2 The Limits of the Atheist Solution

However, the historical record of explicitly secular regimes cautions against an uncritical identification of atheism with the resolution of the problem. The 20th century's most systematic mass killing was conducted by regimes explicitly committed to the elimination of religion: Stalinist Soviet Union, Maoist China, the Khmer Rouge.

These regimes did not lack for absolute frameworks that divided the population into chosen and unchosen, saved and condemned, revolutionary and counter-revolutionary. They replicated the functional structure of election theology — differentiation, divine (or historical) mandate, asymmetric consequence — without its theological content.

This observation suggests that the problem is not religion as such but the *structure* of absolute authority that religion paradigmatically instantiates. The functional equivalent of God — an unchallengeable legitimating source that exempts power from accountability — can be constructed from class history, racial destiny, or national manifest as readily as from divine covenant.

8.3 What Remains After the God Fails

The more precise question, then, is not whether God exists but whether the *values* historically attributed to the divine — justice, illumination, protection of the vulnerable, accountability of the powerful — can be sustained without the theological infrastructure that has so consistently betrayed them.

Several traditions of secular ethics have attempted to answer this affirmatively: Kantian deontology, Rawlsian justice, humanist ethics, existentialist responsibility. The jury on their success remains open. What is clear is that the abandonment of a particular God need not entail the abandonment of the moral aspirations that God was supposed to guarantee.

The values remain. The question of who carries them forward, when the institution charged with their preservation has proven unworthy, is entirely a human question. Which may be, as the analysis above suggests, exactly where we have always actually been.

9 Conclusion

We have traced a coherent arc from the tribal origins of Yahweh through the political theology of election, the cost asymmetry of covenant identity, the technological escalation of religiously legitimated violence, the infallibility paradox, and the contemporary convergence of sacred authority with existential weaponry.

Our central findings may be summarised as follows:

1. The God of institutional Abrahamic religion did not descend from transcendence but ascended from tribal utility, accumulating universal attributes as the political needs of its custodians expanded.

2. The concept of divine election, whatever its theological merits, has operated historically as a mechanism of cost asymmetry: those who construct the identity rarely bear its consequences; those who inherit it do.

3. The technological arc of violence has progressively severed the relationship between the agent of destruction and its victim, making religiously legitimated mass violence both more possible and less personally costly to those who authorise it.

4. A genuinely infallible God would be functionally incompatible with the political uses to which the divine has been put. Its absence from institutional history is therefore not metaphysically surprising but sociologically predictable.

5. The current geopolitical moment represents the most dangerous convergence of these dynamics in human history: multiple actors holding or approaching nuclear capability, operating within frameworks of absolute religious or quasi-religious mandate, in an alliance system capable of rapid escalatory expansion.

6. The values historically attributed to the divine — justice, illumination, accountability — are not dependent on the survival of the theological frameworks that have most consistently betrayed them. They represent a human aspiration that precedes and may outlast the Gods constructed to guarantee them.

Whether those values can be sustained in the absence of transcendent guarantee — whether the arc of the moral universe bends toward justice without a God to bend it — remains the most serious question available to human thought.

It is also, in the present moment, the most urgent.

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Glossary

Chosenness / Election Theology The doctrine, central to Jewish theology and derivatively present in Christianity and Islam, that a particular people or community has been specifically selected by the divine for a unique covenantal relationship. Theologically, this implies both privilege and responsibility; historically, it has also produced the conditions for targeted persecution.

Cost Asymmetry As used in this paper, the systematic divergence between those who construct, maintain, or elaborate a theological or ideological framework and those who bear the practical consequences of that framework. Architects of the framework typically occupy positions of relative safety and authority; inheritors of the identity bear risks they did not choose.

Demiurge In Gnostic theology, a lesser divine being responsible for the creation of the material world, typically characterised as ignorant of or opposed to a higher, transcendent divine reality. Gnostic traditions often identified the God of the Hebrew Bible with the demiurge — powerful but flawed, and not the highest divine principle.

Election See *Chosenness*.

Eschatological Risk Risk associated with end-of-world or civilisationally terminal scenarios. In contemporary usage, nuclear exchange between major powers constitutes the primary eschatological risk. In this paper, the term emphasises the intersection of religious legitimation with weapons capable of irreversible civilisational damage.

ICBM (Intercontinental Ballistic Missile) A long-range ballistic missile capable of delivering nuclear warheads across intercontinental distances. ICBMs represent the current apex of the technological arc described in Section 4: maximum destructive capacity, effectively zero agent accountability, and activation requiring only political decision rather than personal participation in violence.

Infallibility Paradox As formulated in this paper: a genuinely infallible God — perfectly just, universally protective, immune to selective interpretation — would be functionally incompatible with the political uses to which the divine has historically been put, and therefore would never have been institutionally selected. The absence of institutional infallibility is thus less a theological mystery than a sociological necessity.

Monolatry The exclusive worship of one deity while acknowledging the existence of others. Distinguished from monotheism, which denies the existence of other gods entirely. Scholars argue that early Yahwism was monolatrous rather than strictly monotheistic, and that the monotheistic claim developed later.

Process Theology A theological tradition, developed from the philosophy of Alfred North Whitehead, that understands God as genuinely developing in relation to the world, affected by events within creation, and exercising persuasive rather than coercive power. Contrasts with classical theism's insistence on divine immutability and omnipotence.

Theodicy The philosophical and theological attempt to reconcile the existence of a good and powerful God with the existence of evil and suffering. The term derives from the Greek *theos* (God) and *dike* (justice). The Holocaust has become the central test case of modern theodicy, with responses ranging from traditional defences of divine mystery to explicit declarations of divine failure or absence.

Tzimtzum In Lurianic Kabbalah (16th-century Jewish mysticism), the concept that God *contracted* or *withdrew* in order to create space for the world to exist. Implies divine self-limitation rather than unlimited omnipotence, and has been used by modern theologians as a framework for understanding divine non-intervention in historical suffering.

Velayat-e Faqih The doctrine of *guardianship of the Islamic jurist*, foundational to the political theology of the Islamic Republic of Iran, as developed by Ayatollah Khomeini. Holds that in the absence of the Hidden Imam, supreme political authority rightly belongs to the senior Islamic jurist. Represents a contemporary example of the conflation of divine authority with political sovereignty.

Yahwism The religion centred on the worship of Yahweh, the God of Israel. In its early form (as reconstructed by scholars), a regional cult associated with warrior and storm deity attributes. In its developed form, the foundation of the Abrahamic monotheistic traditions.

The End